

Josh Chung — Story Elevation Guide

Three Tiers of Value Framework | Mock Interview Prep | Field Service Engineer (Early Career)

Three Tiers of Value (IBB Framework)

★ **You Did What Was Asked** — Describes a duty. No metric, no method, no outcome. Gets skipped.

★★ **You Went Above and Beyond** — Real accomplishment with specifics, but missing full impact chain. Gets considered.

★★★ **You Spread the Impact Far and Wide** — Full formula. Value reaches beyond you — trained others, adopted across teams, affected the business. Gets hired.

Story 1 — Lighting Installation / Safety Compliance

Session 2, Question 1 | Competency: Problem-Solving & Technical Judgment

Right now your answer is at ★ — you described following OSHA regs and installing lights. Anyone on that crew could tell the same story. To move it up, you need to show what *you specifically* did that someone else wouldn't have.

Five ways to push this to ★★ (Above and Beyond):

1. Did you catch something during the job that others missed — a spec mismatch, a hazard, a wrong material — before it became a problem?
2. Did you create any kind of checklist, walkthrough order, or personal system to make sure you didn't skip steps, rather than just "following the rules"?
3. Were you the one who taught or briefed coworkers on the handling procedures, and if so, what specifically did you show them that they didn't already know?
4. Did you finish faster, with fewer issues, or with a cleaner inspection result than similar jobs — and can you put a number on it?
5. Did the client give any specific feedback or was there a specific quality check you passed that you can point to as proof it went well?

Five ways to push this to ★★★ (Spread Impact Far and Wide):

1. Did anything you did on that job change how the crew handled the next job — a new step, a new check, a different order of operations?
2. Did you bring what you learned back to your supervisor and suggest a process change, even informally?
3. Did any coworker start doing something differently because of what you showed them on that project?
4. Could you have documented the safety procedure you followed and turned it into a reference for new hires or future crews?
5. Did the client relationship improve or lead to repeat work because of how your team handled safety — and did anything you did specifically contribute to that?

Story 2 — Bridge Capstone / Leadership

Session 1, Question 1 | Competency: Leadership & Initiative

You're between ★ and ★★ here. You mention leading the team and using FEA, but your Action section is one sentence and you default to "we" the entire time. The coach flagged that directly. To move up, you need to separate what *you personally* decided, built, or figured out from what the team did together.

Five ways to push this to ★★ (Above and Beyond):

1. You predicted the failure point would be top-left — did you make that call before anyone else on the team saw it? What led you to that specific conclusion?
2. When the physical test matched your simulation within 5%, did that change a decision the team was about to make — like which design iteration to go with?
3. Did you choose the mesh settings, boundary conditions, or load cases yourself, and did any of those choices differ from what a textbook default would have been?
4. Were there moments where your simulation results disagreed with what a teammate expected, and you had to defend your analysis? How did that play out?
5. Did your FEA work save the team from building a prototype iteration that would have failed — i.e., did your analysis prevent wasted time or materials?

Five ways to push this to ★★★ (Spread Impact Far and Wide):

1. Did you share your simulation setup — load cases, mesh settings, boundary conditions — with any other teams in the course who were struggling?
2. Did your professor or TA reference your prediction-vs-test results as an example for others, or for future semesters?
3. Did you create any reusable template, file, or workflow that someone after you could pick up and use without starting from scratch?
4. Did your approach to the simulation change how your teammates thought about FEA on their own future projects — did anyone tell you they learned something from watching you work?
5. Did the way you structured the testing (incremental loads, documenting failure behavior) get adopted as a method by your team for subsequent iterations?

Story 3 — Robotic Gripper / TPU Troubleshooting

Session 1, Question 2 | Competency: Problem-Solving & Technical Judgment

This is your strongest story — you're already close to ★★. You diagnosed a real problem (stringing, layer separation), identified root cause (extruder temp, fan speed), and got to a working prototype. But your impact stops at "we got a working gripper." To get to ★★★ you need to show what happened *after* you solved it.

Five ways to solidify ★★ (Above and Beyond):

1. How many failed prints happened before you diagnosed it — and how much time or material did that waste? Quantify the cost of the problem.
2. Had anyone else in the lab tried printing TPU on that machine before you? If not, you were the first to figure it out — say that.
3. What specifically told you it was a temperature issue versus a speed issue versus a bed adhesion issue? Walk through your diagnostic logic, not just the fix.
4. Did getting the gripper working on time keep the broader research project on schedule — what would have happened if you hadn't figured it out?
5. Your coach noted that your process improvement thinking came out in +1 and +2 instead of the main answer — pull that diagnostic reasoning into your Action section where it belongs.

Five ways to push this to ★★★ (Spread Impact Far and Wide):

1. Did you write down the TPU settings that worked — temperature, fan speed, bed prep — anywhere that someone else could find them later?
2. Did the PI or any other lab member start using your settings for their own prints after you figured it out?
3. Did solving the TPU problem open up a new material option for the lab that they didn't have before — could they now print flexible parts when they previously couldn't?
4. Did any future research assistant avoid the same troubleshooting cycle because of something you left behind — a note, a settings file, a conversation?
5. Did your gripper prototype become the version that got used in the actual research data collection, meaning your fabrication work directly enabled published results?

The pattern across all three: Your current answers stop at "I did the thing and it worked." ★★ adds *how specifically* you did it and *what it proved*. ★★★ adds *who else benefited* and *what changed after you*. That last layer is what separates "good engineer" from "engineer I need to hire."